

Question for a Uni Design Project: Is the massive energy footprint of AI actually on your radar?

Posted by u/TalNix77 • 0 points • 4 comments

Hi everyone,

I'm a design student researching the "invisible" energy consumption of AI for a university project.

While the utility of tools like ChatGPT is obvious, the physical resources required to run them are massive. Studies suggest that a single generative AI query can consume significantly more energy than a standard web search (some estimates range from 10x to 25x more).

I'm looking for honest perspectives on this:

1. **Awareness:** Before reading this, were you actually aware of the scale of energy difference between a standard search and an AI prompt? Or is that completely "invisible" in your daily usage?
2. **Impact on Usage:** Does the energy intensity play any role in how you use these tools? Or is the utility simply the only factor that matters for your workflow?
3. **Value vs. Waste:** Do you view this high energy consumption as a fair investment for the results you get, or does the current technology feel inefficient to you?

I'm trying to get a realistic picture of whether this topic actually plays a role in users' minds or if performance is the priority.

Comments

u/tippinex • 1 points • 2025-12-06 00:30 UTC

1. i'm aware
2. i've never used ai

3. ai is a hot mess and gets lots of stuff wrong. yes it's convenient but it has LITERALLY gotten people killed. it's being used to generate child porn and porn in general of people who never consented. it was giving people psychotic breakdowns. i know your paper is about waste but like holy hell y'know

ai could be a great tool one day, but we are NOT prepared for it right now.

u/AgentElman • 1 points • 2025-12-06 00:13 UTC

No. There is not a massive AI energy footprint.

People deceptively pretend AI has a massive energy footprint by comparing it to things with low energy use such as standard web search rather than streaming video or playing online video games.

There was not a big internet movement against the energy use of streaming video or playing online video games. This is clearly just a manufactured outrage targeting AI with no regards to the actual energy consumption.

u/Concise_Pirate • 1 points • 2025-12-06 00:09 UTC

I think about it at a policy level, but not my personal behavior -- I think my fridge and my car each use way, way more energy than any amount of AI that I use.

u/Even-Chemistry-707 • 1 points • 2025-12-06 00:51 UTC

Yeah same here, it's like worrying about leaving a light on while your AC is blasting 24/7. The big picture stuff matters but my personal ChatGPT usage is probably a drop in the bucket compared to literally everything else I do